

PAPER NO. 26-23

WANDSWORTH BOROUGH COUNCIL

STANDARDS COMMITTEE – 26 January 2026

Report by the Director of Law and Governance on Member Induction and Refresher Programme – 2026

SUMMARY

This report sets out the proposed induction and training programme for new and returning Members of following the local elections in May 2026. It details the structure, content, and support mechanisms designed to equip Members with necessary knowledge and skills for their roles.

GLOSSARY

CfGS – Centre for Governance and Scrutiny

LGA - Local Government Association

LGiU – Local Government Information Unit

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. This report is submitted to the Standards Committee for information. No decisions are required on it by the Council, the Cabinet or regulatory or other committees. The Committee is asked to note the proposed programme.

INTRODUCTION

2. New Members must quickly acquire the knowledge and skills needed for their roles within the council. The Member induction programme will cover key training, briefings, and departmental introductions.
3. A structured induction programme helps equip Members with essential knowledge, tools, and officer introductions. The induction programme will:
 - Explain the purpose of induction and importance of ongoing development
 - Offer support available for new and returning Councillors
 - Key councillor roles and responsibilities
 - Access to council equipment and systems
 - Overview of key council services
 - Members' Code of Conduct requirements
 - Statutory responsibilities

DETAILS

4. A welcome evening has been scheduled for **Monday 11 May**. This event will ensure that Members are able to complete the necessary paperwork and processes to formally take up their office as a Councillor.
5. The Members Fair allows directorates and key officers to meet Members, introduce themselves, explain their work, and answer questions. This has been scheduled for **Wednesday 13 May** and will take place in the Civic Suite.
6. Candidates will be informed of the induction programme in advance, enabling successful candidates to reserve the relevant dates ahead of the local elections.
7. Following the elections, Members will receive a comprehensive handbook containing essential contacts and information, as well as the full induction programme. This resource will also include guidance on managing casework, as well as key email addresses.
8. **Induction**
A review of the 2022 induction programme identified essential training requirements, informing proposals for 2026 and beyond. The induction programme be delivered over 12–18 months, encompassing a range of topics outlined in the draft programme. The first phase will include mandatory courses as part of the initial induction, followed by skills development and a focus on key Council services.

Officers will also provide regular updates and guidance on the Member Portal to support flexible learning. Details of the proposed programme are attached as Appendix 1.
9. **Role Specific Training**
Targeted training will be provided for specific roles, including Lead Members and Committee Chairs. Additionally, when portfolios change, newly appointed Members will receive targeted training to be able to discharge their new responsibilities.
10. **Individual Support**
In some cases, individual development needs may be addressed on a one-on-one basis, such as providing support with IT skills or for Members with specific learning requirements.
11. **External Development Activities**
Event updates from accredited training organisations such as the LGA and LGiU will be shared with Members throughout the year. Members will be able to apply for relevant external courses, and to ensure a fair allocation of access, approval will be needed from the Head of Support and Member Services.

External development activities will normally be reserved for Lead Members, including Lead Members from the Opposition.

12. Personal Development

When knowledge or skills gaps are identified, officers can suggest/signpost appropriate training activities to address these needs to help Members support their own development.

Members are encouraged to take a proactive approach to their development by exploring various options, such as requesting a one-on-one session with an officer, participating in site visits, consulting more experienced Members, conducting personal research, or attending external events. Officers will help and guide Members throughout this process.

13. ICT Equipment

It is likely that an offer of iPads with data packages to Members will be made in May 2026. While current ICT options, such as laptops, will remain available to Members, we are committed to helping Members fulfil their responsibilities efficiently, and distributing iPads will further support their ability to serve their communities effectively. Officers will endeavour to provide IT support tailored to individual needs. For example, where members are willing to use their own devices, the council will explore how best to enable them to access the network through two factor authentication. Mobile devices will be discontinued, as iPads will be able to support the ability for calls via Microsoft Teams, included as part of data packages.

Members who step down/are not re-elected will as in previous years will be required to return all devices, and guidance will be issued to Members with regards to handling data.

14. Survey

After the initial 3-4 months of the induction program, we will collect feedback from Members to identify possible improvements or suggestions. Since there may be requests for additional training, Member input will be essential for refining the program.

COMMENTS OF THE EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR OF FINANCE

15. The cost of the Member Induction Programme will be met from existing budgets. The purchase of iPads including any data packages is subject to the budget review process.

CONCLUSION

16. The Member Induction Programme aims to provide Members with the necessary tools and support to carry out their roles effectively. By introducing iPads with data packages and seeking regular feedback, we are committed to ensuring the programme remains responsive to Member needs.

Abdus Choudhury
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16th January 2026